



Headwaters

The beginning, or source, of a river is called its headwaters. Some come from underground springs, while others are fed by mountain snow.

Tributary

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A tributary is a river or stream that feeds into another river, rather than ending in a lake or ocean. If a river is large, it is likely fed by a number of tributaries.

Flow

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A river's flow is the amount of water in the channel. The flow often changes throughout the year, with many rivers running high during rainy seasons, and running low during the dry summer months.

River Channel

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The path a river takes is called a channel. Its shape and size depend on the amount of water that has been flowing in it, how long it has been flowing, and the type of rocks and soil over which it flows.

Floodplain

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A floodplain is a flat, low-lying area along the river that gets covered with water when the river overflows. Building in floodplains can be dangerous, because of the risk of frequent flooding.

Riverbank

Riverbank

The land immediately along the river is the riverbank. Riverbanks are constantly changing, sculpted by the flowing river. The trees and other vegetation on a riverbank provide important habitat for birds and other wildlife.

Wetlands

Wetlands

A wetland is a low-lying area where water covers the soil for much of the year. Also known as a swamp, bog, or marsh, a wetland provides habitat to a wide variety of plants and animals.

Mouth / Delta

Mouth / Delta

The end of the river, where it meets a lake or ocean, is called the mouth, or delta.